

THE N WORD

Net Neutrality. A controversial term headlining our country's Internet debate. What's the big deal with Free Basics? Why is it uniting and dividing opinions? Why should you care?

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Throughout the past couple of decades since the Internet came to fore, we've always accepted it as something that just is. Whether you connect to Wi-Fi at a coffee shop or access the Internet on your smartphone's cellular 3G connection. During all these instances, you always accessed the unabridged Internet. Or did you?

We never thought about the possibility that the Internet could be off limits, that it would have a mind of its own when it served websites you requested. Not counting government censorship or the disconnection of your Internet broadband due to non-payment of your monthly "Internet bill" (or subscription cost), you never realized that the Internet that manifested itself on your PC's monitor screen could be behaving unnaturally. Whenever our Internet connection fluctuated for better or worse we either smiled or agonized, using the opportunity to either download a large file through BitTorrent (with plenty of seeds) or picking up the phone and yelling at your ISP's customer support operator. When a website loaded slowly or a YouTube video wouldn't play stutter-free, we always thought the problem was on the server side, that our Internet connection was largely not at fault and for the most part above suspicion – unless it was below 2 Mbps.

This fundamental perception of the Internet changed dramatically in 2015, as a national debate that had been raging only in the US till 2014 found a voice amongst public advocacy groups and

Internet stakeholders here in India. Net Neutrality reared its controversial head in a battle to control the sanctity of a free and fair Internet in India.

WHAT IS NET NEUTRALITY?

While there is no standard definition for the term Net Neutrality, according to Tim Wu, Professor at Columbia Law School, credited with coining the term, it's "best defined as a network design principle. The idea is that a maximally useful public information network aspires to treat all content, sites, and platforms equally. This allows the network to carry every form of information and support every kind of application." In essence, Net Neutrality dictates that all data is to be treated equally. This means that your ISP will treat your request to access Facebook.com or Google Plus, Flipkart.com or Amazon.in, Google.com or Bing.com, Netflix.com or Erosnow.com, ThePirateBay.se, Pastebin.com, or Mega.nz without distinction and on equal priority. The ISP won't play favourites when it comes to serving one site better than the other.

According to this view of Net Neutrality, the ISP cannot and should not differentiate between or prioritize different types of data (Email, VOIP, Video, etc) travelling through the network, and that all data being served to the ISP's customer (the end user) should be done on a "best effort" basis with no exceptions. This should be done in a transparent and bias-free manner.

Just like the electricity being served into our homes doesn't differentiate between powering up an oven, toaster, refrigerator,

washing machine, air conditioner or television – it reaches all of them in a fair manner as long as there's unrestricted supply – so should the ISPs look at data packets being served to its customers over the Internet highways. Data should be served as best as possible with a fixed (monthly) cost for access to the network without questioning where the data is coming from or what type of data it is or preferentially charging for some types of data services over others. Period.

Another aspect of Net Neutrality, according to its proponents and advocates, is that every user who is connecting to the Internet must have equal access to all of the data services delivered through the network. If a farmer is connecting to the Internet over a low-speed EDGE connection through his smartphone's cellular network to get essential data like weather patterns, market rate for goods, etc., if he wants to stream a YouTube video or access any random website on the Web, technically he can access the Web and other Internet services as long as he hasn't hit his FUP data cap. It's possible. Why? Because data is served to him regardless of where it's coming from (Weather.com, Accu-weather.com or Youtube) without any discrimination and in a transparent manner. When that farmer connects to the Internet, it should be an unrestricted, unabridged connection. Not doing so is denying him the opportunity to connect to the same Internet that you and I browse.

This could fracture the very ethos of the Internet as it now exists. Instead of one overarching network which doesn't care